

GRADUATE RESEARCH CENTRE

Mid-Candidature Review Guidelines

For Candidates presenting for Mid-Candidature Review in 2017

Please note:

These Guidelines only apply to candidates who have been advised by the Graduate Research Centre (GRC) that they are required to present for Mid-Candidature Review in 2017. All other candidates should refer to the 2018 Guidelines (to be released late 2017).

Statement of Purpose

Congratulations, you are half way through your research degree!

The Mid-Candidature Review is the second milestone you will meet in your Higher Degree by Research (HDR) enrolment. This milestone is an opportunity for you to present your progress to date and receive valuable feedback from a Panel of experts in the research community. Your presentation will be conducted in a supportive and engaging environment, thus enabling you to further enhance your communication and presentation skills within an academic context. The feedback you receive is designed to ensure that you are on track to a timely and successful completion, that your research skills are developing appropriately and that the supervisory arrangements are appropriate.

A. Mid-Candidature Review Components

The Mid-Candidature Review will take the following into consideration:

- Has the candidate's progress since Confirmation remained satisfactory in relation to feasibility and viability of the proposed project and in relation to the requirements of the degree in which they are enrolled?
- Has there been a significant change in research direction since Confirmation? If yes, the candidate is required to submit a new research proposal to the Graduate Research Centre for consideration by the relevant College. Significant changes may include:
 - a. a major change to the project plan
 - b. a major change in resourcing and/or support
 - c. a change in academic supervision for the new research direction.
- Does the candidate remain on track to complete their research project by their submission date?
- Can the continuation of adequate supervision, resources and infrastructure within the College be ensured in order to enable completion within the required timeframe?
- Are the candidate's research skills developing appropriately via the successful completion of coursework units (where applicable), workshop attendance and training programs as per their program requirements and the demands of their particular project and goals? Reference should be made to the most recent VU MyPlan to identify strategic planning for priority skills/learning areas

- What recommendations were made by the Confirmation of Candidature panel and how have they been addressed by the project? Where relevant, are Ethics and Intellectual Property (IP) measures in place?

B. Requirements for Mid-Candidature Review

i. Oral Presentation (20 mins):

The student is required to make a 20 minute oral presentation to the Review Panel and University community. The oral presentation must explore at least one aspect of research undertaken to date; this should be clearly situated within the overall context of the whole project and note anticipated future directions of the research program. It is expected that the candidate will use power point slides (a maximum of 10) to support their presentation. The presentation will be followed by time for questions from members of the audience (10 mins). Feedback from the Review Panel will be given in a closed session- panel members only (10 mins). All Supervisors will be asked to leave the room for the final session to review overall progress to date (this will be in lieu of the Annual Progress Review) (10 mins).

ii. Written Submission:

1. One completed draft chapter or equivalent (if PhD by Creative Project and Exegesis this should include elements of both creative and exegetical material). Required total word length 7-10,000 words)
2. A summary paper (no more than 5 pages), briefly outlining the Aims of the Project, Statement of Significance, Methodology and Analysis and Interpretation.

C. Constitution and Composition of Review Panel

The role of the Review Panel is to undertake a high quality and independent review of the two elements of the Mid-Candidature Review – the written submission and oral presentation.

The proposed Panel Composition* is as follows:

- Chair – College Director, Research and Research Training or their nominee;
- A Discipline Leader or academic who has expertise relevant to the candidate's research area, but has not been involved in the candidate's supervision;
- An academic and active researcher with appropriate qualifications and relevant supervisory experience. This person may, but does not necessarily have to be, an expert in the specific field of research, provided they have broad knowledge and expertise in relation to research in the field. It is expected that this panel member should be external** to the College in which the candidate is enrolled.

* Where possible, the Panel should be the same Panel convened for Confirmation of Candidature.

** If an external panel member to the University is nominated, a request for reimbursement of travel costs must be approved by the College Director prior to confirmation of the panel.

D. Review Process:

- Candidates and supervisors will be advised of the scheduled Mid-Candidature oral presentation date shortly following Confirmation of Candidature approval by the College Support Officer (CSO), GRC.
- Panel composition: Where possible, the Confirmation of Candidature Panel will reconvene. Where this is not possible, the Principal Supervisor will nominate an academic and active researcher with appropriate qualifications to the CSO, GRC, at least one month prior to the scheduled presentation date, for approval by the College Director or nominee.
- Once the panel has been approved by the College Director, Research and Research Training or their nominee, meeting invitations will be circulated to all participants in a timely manner by the CSO, GRC.
- A completed '*Application for Mid-Candidature Review*' will be due 2 weeks prior to the scheduled presentation date and will be circulated to the panel by the CSO, GRC, with the written submission.
- When the panel convenes, the College will designate a panel writer responsible for the draft of the final panel report. This is normally the Chair or another panel member.
- The CSO will send a global email indicating the time, venue, date of the presentation and inviting fellow graduate researchers and supervisors to attend the scheduled oral presentations.

- Following the oral presentation and discussion, Panel members will discuss the written submission and oral presentation in private to determine the classification category. At the conclusion of these discussions, the candidate will be verbally advised of the panel's recommendations and any other feedback and suggestions. Formal written confirmation of the panel's deliberations will follow after the meeting.
- The Chair will ensure that the panel report and recommendation on Mid Candidature confirmation is forwarded to the CSO, GRC, within 7 days of the oral presentation.
- Upon receipt of the report, the CSO, GRC, will email all relevant documentation to the candidate/supervisors and confirm the Panel's classification of the review.
- Suggested feedback will be forwarded to the CSO, GRC, for distribution to the candidate and supervisors.
- Final approval of the '*Application for Mid-Candidature Review*' lies with the Panel Chair.

If exceptional circumstances prevent the candidate from presenting on the nominated date, an alternative date may be requested. **Exceptional circumstances** will be considered on a case by case basis and include medical, personal or family circumstances (documentary evidence required). The request would normally need to be made no less than 14 days prior to the scheduled Mid-Candidature presentation.

E. Classification of the Mid-Candidature Review

The panel will classify one of the following outcomes:

1. The outcome is satisfactory and the candidature should be continued.
2. The outcome is satisfactory, subject to the recommendations of the Panel being made within the timelines stipulated by the Panel (normally 3 months EFT but no more than 6 months EFT).
3. The candidate is not making satisfactory progress (as detailed in the Panel Report) and the outcome should be recorded as unsatisfactory. The College may commence Unsatisfactory Progress proceedings.
4. The doctoral candidate is not making satisfactory progress (as detailed in the Panel Report) and should convert to a Masters by Research.

F. Scholarship holders

Scholarship recipients are reminded that continuation of a scholarship is subject to satisfactory progress being made. Scholarship stipends will normally be suspended under either of the following conditions:

1. The candidate does not present for mid candidature review under the timelines stipulated above; and/or
2. The College commences Unsatisfactory Progress proceedings.